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Chuck Findley

Chuck Findley's versatility as a trumpet player has allowed him to have a presence in every genre of recorded music. His distinctive sound as a soloist and as a lead player enabled him to find success with the Buddy Rich Big Band, on the Tonight Show Band with Doc Severinsen, and in every conceivable studio situation.

Chuck was interviewed via Zoom on September 6, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and boy, I'm very happy to have Chuck Findley with me today. And one of your colleagues, who is a decent trumpet player named Jerry Hey said, "Chuck Findley can play anything."

CF: Well that's a lovely compliment I must say, Monk. Well I'll tell you that really goes back to like when we were recording the lovely Al Jarreau stuff and just a lot of ridiculous things. And Jerry was a wonderful trumpet player when he could play, but then he had an issue with his throat and he couldn't play anymore so he just became a writer, which he was anyhow, and he became a fantastic commercial writer. But Jerry would always, he would play everything he wrote before he brought it to a session, and, to make sure everybody could play it, which was — and it was difficult. And he was, like I said, what a marvelous trumpet player Jerry was. So he would play it, so we knew that it was playable, not necessarily going to be easy — but we knew it was playable. And well if you've heard any of the things that Jerry's ever written and the things that we played, you would know how difficult it was. But back in those days, like I said — well I didn't say it yet to you, to the people, but we were very busy running from one date to another date and back and forth. Gary Grant was also involved with that sessions, in the trumpet section, the three of us. But now we're talking about in the '70's now, mid-'70's to '80's and all that. But way before that I was playing, well the records for me started, really started when I came here to town in — I moved here in '69 and in '70 I was very, very busy. Ollie Mitchell was my guru and Ollie basically got me started into records. You know he just took me with him everywhere and I was working three sessions a day besides jingles and film calls and movies as well. But it was — my breakthrough was at A&M — as a soloist I'm getting at, Monk — is when they asked me — it was for the Carpenters and it was on the tune "Close to You" and I played that flugelhorn solo on "Close to You" and I double tracked it and everybody heard that and from then on I got called to do so many solos on records, commercial records, Monk. Not jazz records.

MR: That is so interesting because I went and revisited that and it's literally four bars plus a two-beat pick-up. And the fact that it brought you that recognition and that — Herb Alpert had something to do with that song, didn't he?

CF: Well Burt Bacharach wrote it. And Herb was supposed to do the solo on it. And I think he did and they weren't happy with it. So I'll tell you on that session there were three trumpets. It was myself, it was Ollie Mitchell, and Buddy Childers. The three of us. Now at the end of the date — Buddy did the solo first, on flugelhorn. That was another thing, Buddy did it and then after the date was over they asked me to stay and asked me to do it and I did it and that's the one that was used. Now Buddy thought he had done it. It was — you know and I never went out and said well Buddy didn't do it, I did it, you know, because I loved Buddy and he was a marvelous player. I just let it alone and of course people found out that I did it later. And then from there I just, like I said, there's so many different solos on commercial records from that.

MR: Yeah.

CF: I was very busy before that though, as well.

MR: Yeah, before we leave that, there's the lick, it's not even a doit, but [scats] there's a very slight thing where you, you know you slide up and — was that hard to double? And did you listen to yourself the first time you did it did you have headphones and then you're listening to the first time to add the second?

CF: Absolutely. I — getting back to that, the doit, the [scats] and it's an F sharp, E concert. It's very hard to dip into that note. And Burt Bacharach of course, who wrote the song, I don't know if you know that Burt was very particular with what he wanted. We'd do something twelve times and end up with the first one. You know but you know you're talking about the separation of [scats] — that's the wrong key [scats] You know? Okay so now getting back to doubling and that, I wore the cans, always on one ear and off on the other one so I could hear myself. And it actually I just did it one time, the double. 'Cause in the natural reverb on that they didn't have to use reverb in the booth because when you play the same thing yourself you have natural reverb. And it worked out perfect. But I've been told by many, many trumpet players that they do these different gigs, hardest gigs, and that particular tune comes up and when they have to play that solo they're scared to death to play it. Because it's so simple but also so difficult at the same time.

MR: You answered a question I was going to ask because I recently watched this marvelous performance of yours with "Nature Boy" and the James Last Orchestra.

CF: Yeah?

MR: Man, I mean that one performance sort of encapsulates what you're capable of with the soloing and the respectful treatment of the melody and then some really high, high notes. So when you think of "Close to You" and that performance is one harder than the other?

CF: I'd say "Close to You" was harder, only because I wasn't free to improvise on anything like that. It had to be done note by note. Right? I mean on "Nature Boy" I was free to do whatever I pleased to do. So I could — every night I had to play it so I'd play it different every night. You know, it wasn't that I had to do it — and of course the melody you play but the melody also is not just the melody the way I'd play it the night before. I'd play it differently every night, 'cause that's what an artist does or at least what I do anyhow. I mean there are many, many players that play notes you know. Anybody could play the music that's written in front of them. I mean they could practice and shed you know eight hours a day for all their life and they can't improvise at all but they can play the notes that are on the paper. That is not being an artist that I consider an artist or a creative person. But the schooling of being a precise player, like you had mentioned, is very, very important. And I recommend that studying classical music is — you need to have that. That's the basis. You have the basis down and then you go from there. It's like I played with records and records when I was growing up, and I'd play — Jeez it started with Bobby Hackett. Because my brother was my idol and still is, he's eight years older than me, my brother Bob, and so I had the cornet, that's why I started. And Bobby Hackett was the records that I played. My dad was also a wonderful saxophone player and doubled on violin. So we had music in our house all the time, all the time, I mean live music. People would come over and play. So I thought that was the normal, natural thing, people would have these jam sessions, you know?

MR: Yeah. Let me ask you about that because I heard you talking about that and that your dad would play in restaurants and he would stroll, he'd pick up the violin and maybe stroll around. And I wondered, did you and your brother Bob actually witness that? Did you go to these places?

CF: My brother may have, since he's eight years older than me. I did not. But I did — he would take me to gigs when I was fourteen, playing with the big band. I'd be like playing fourth, I was thrilled to death to be there. I couldn't drive yet, and he would drive me there and he'd sit at the bar and have a beer and he knew everybody in the band. And he was so proud of me you know. He'd sit there, he wasn't on the gig. But it was wonderful you know. All that happened when I was young, like I say, fourteen years old you know. I joined the union around that time too. I couldn't drive, but I would do gigs and I was still of course in school so after the gig, you know, I'd sleep in the back seat with the drums or something like that in the car you know. But I always played, no matter where I

was I would always go and take a cab or if I could walk to the jazz club doing one-nighters, every night I'd play. And that's how you learn.

MR: I was just going to say what did you learn from sitting next to those older fellas in the big band situation? Just — beyond — not only the playing of the music but just an observation of how they behaved?

CF: Well you know what? Well sitting next to Snooky, sitting next to Sweets, sitting next to I mean I could go down the line you know, Conte Candoli, Pete Candoli, John Audino, Ray Trisceri, Uan Rasey, Jimmy Zito, just so many players that I worked with all the time that I mean I'm talking about a daily basis I'd work with these people. And what I learned from them was well first of all they were very relaxed and they did not — they weren't uptight at all. You know there were a few people that were and I won't mention any names who they were but there were a few. But most everybody, it was a family. We just got along. What I learned from them was just to play my horn like I did when I was a kid, you know I was just playing my horn, having fun, make music. And when you're in a happy environment you make happy music. It comes out that way you know. It's not stiff. It's not like business music you know today, in this day and age it is business of music. It's all about business. And like I mentioned earlier to you, before we started the Zoom is that these people, they get there an hour early before the session you know. The contractor is wondering where they are if they're not there. I hope you're not hearing that somebody's —

MR: I'm not actually.

CF: Okay. I got a little ping on my — I don't know what they want now. Anyhow no, it was fun, it was great, working in Louie Bellson's big band when I first moved to town, you know it was just wonderful. It was like playing in another club. Doing a session was like playing in a club. And we did the "Trilogy" album for Frank Sinatra, when I did that you know there was — nothing was uptight. It was all — we were making great music for Frank and Frank did one take and that's it. You know? It wasn't like twelve takes. Like there's so many things like that nowadays — well nowadays they can punch in one note you know and they fly it into another part of the tune you know, because it sounded better than the one you did later, so they pick the best one. You know it's like putting together a puzzle is what they do. That loses the magic and the beauty of the art of music and creativity.

MR: It sounds like you're describing a situation that there was so much work and so many good musicians but it was not competitive. Like how come they called that guy for this gig instead of me but that wasn't a necessary thing that happened at the time.

CF: It did — it did happen but it was only because of the performance. And personalities had

no names, but that were not the nicest, you know, person to have in the band. But in general I'd say 90 percent of them or more were wonderful, happy people. You know and like I said that happiness comes out through that piece of brass that you have in your hands. And what you hear Sweets play, Sweets had a signature — oh he was funny too, very funny I mean so we'd tell jokes and lines and things. Well I mean if anything the leader would have to tell us, "Hey come on guys, be a little quiet here" you know because we were having too much fun. But it came out on the record, the beauty of having fun through music. And that's the way I always grew up and when I played I always had fun.

MR: Did you sit next to Jack Sheldon on occasion?

CF: Oh yeah, oh yeah I sure did. I've got a couple of stories about that too, I don't know — well yeah, I could tell you, I could tell you, beautiful. We were at Universal, we had a nine in the morning call and there was a double session and it was a Monday. And we called him "The Creeper." Jack was The Creeper. And the reason he was called The Creeper was cause he'd creep in and then he'd creep out. And so we're doing this nine in the morning double session at Universal and the contractor's name was Bobby Helfer. And Bobby was a real, real, I mean he was absolutely fantastic as a contractor as far as if we went 30 seconds over we got overtime, we got 20 minutes overtime. I mean he did not give in at all. He was really a wonderful contractor for musicians. But he was also very — he didn't want anybody to — he wouldn't go to lunch with anybody or anything like that because he thought they were kissing ass and they would want work from him. So anyhow so he's the contractor at Universal. Now Jack's on the call. Everybody's there, and like I said it wasn't an hour before, we'd get there ten minutes, five minutes before the session, get out our horns and get ready to perform. And no Jack. Jack's not there. So nine o'clock goes by, ten after nine, twenty after, no Jack. Well somebody mentioned that Jack was in San Francisco that weekend, he was doing a gig in San Francisco. So Jack comes in and as he's walking in Bobby Helfer immediately goes up to him as he's walking in to come to his chair and he says to him, he says, before he could say anything he says, "I got fogged in, Bobby." And Bobby said, "I called. There was no fog, and there was no reason —" And Jack Sheldon says, "Bobby," he says, "there are many ways to get fogged in." That was Jack's line. And Jack came and sat down next to me and we did the session and everything was beautiful. Jack was wonderful. And at the end of the double date, so 9-12 and 1-4, at 4:00 I'm putting — I'm pretty quick because I had another session to go to and I'm putting my horns away. I turned and Jack's gone. The Creeper was gone. So he would creep in and creep out and but his personality was so beautiful and he was so funny and just a sweetheart of a man and so natural. I mean you hear Jack you know it's Jack Sheldon playing. You know I saw one of the interviews you

how you had to be an individual. How you had to create your own sound. That's the case with me and the people that I worked with back in the day. When you heard Conrad Gozzo playing lead you knew it was Conrad Gozzo you know. When you heard Conte Candoli playing a solo, you knew it was Conte Candoli. You heard Pete Candoli you knew it was Pete Candoli. You know it's just — Plas Johnson, you knew it was Plas Johnson. I listened to everybody and I picked up everybody from playing records and records and sitting next to them and playing and picking up their little innuendoes and a little of this, a little of that, a little of that, and I picked it all up and I put it all together and then I became myself. And when you become yourself then you have a signature. And so I listened to Lee Morgan, I listened to Kenny Dorham, I listened to — after Bobby Hackett this is. But Bobby Hackett was the one that got me playing like lyrical and tunes and stuff like that. And then I listened to Lee Morgan and like I said, and Nat Adderley I listened to as well. And then oh there were so many people. And of course Clifford and Miles. And you know for what it's worth when I was playing and I heard Miles, Miles did not touch me like Clifford did or Lee Morgan or Kenny Dorham, players like Charlie Shavers — there was something about that. Miles was different, completely different. His own signature. And I didn't understand that then. But then the next person was Maynard Ferguson. And talking about a culture shock — because these records my brother had you know and I would play along with all these records. And my brother's on the road and I'm upstairs in our house in Mayfield Heights in the suburbs of Cleveland playing along with these records. Well I'd go from cornet to trumpet and now I'm trying to play along with Maynard. Well I'll tell ya, he made me work really hard but I got it you know, and I got it and I was able to do it and play along with his records. Play "Maria" and play all these different things. And so like I said, three things I don't like to do is play high, loud and fast. Those are three things I don't like to do. When I want to hear a person's soul and hear them play, have them play me a ballad and then I'll know who they are. Because you can't tell who they are when they're playing like — well we did that "Cherokee" with Arturo Sandoval and I mean how can you tell a person's — what their soul is like when you hear that? I mean it's just notes that are flying by a mile a minute you know, and then high notes. It doesn't tell you anything.

MR: Do you have a sense — I'm going to refer back to that "Nature Boy" recording because there's some pretty sophisticated orchestrations behind you. Do you have the kind of ear and chordal knowledge that you know what those chords are when you're improvising over them?

CF: Yes I do. I do. And I learned that — I was born with perfect pitch so I hear all the inner voices and everything that's going on, I hear them all. So when I first started playing jazz

player and very nice, and he would come over to the house, I mean he'd be at the house and his friend Lenny Russo was a drummer who I worked with and I used to sit in the back seat with his drums on these gigs when I was fourteen but he'd be there and they'd play the blues. I'll never forget it. They'd start playing the blues, B flat blues, and my brother says to me, "Play." I said, "Play what?" He said, "Just play." So I started playing and when it would go to the four chord if I hit the wrong note on the four chord, then the five chord, whatever it was, then we'd go back to the root and start over, you know we'd just do chorus after chorus after chorus. And when I'd get to the four chord the second time around I sure wouldn't play that note because it didn't fit. And also the same thing with the five chord. And it was just over and over, it was a matter of just playing and hearing and knowing what sounded right and what fit and what didn't fit. Then later on in life you learn that all the notes fit if you want to put them in a certain place in a certain melodic line or a phrase that you're playing, you know. You can go out. You can go as far out as you want you know and I don't know if people would enjoy listening to it but it's, you know, if that makes any sense to you I mean you could really take it out.

MR: It does. I think Bill Watrous said you can go out but you better know how to come back in.

CF: Of course. You have to come back to make some sense to it, you don't want them to leave if you're playing a live concert, a live performance. You know it's like, and growing up I played in Cleveland, and I played in this one band it was called, well the club was called — well the club was called Paderewski's and it was, the family was related to Ignace Paderewski from Poland — the famous composer. And I think he was the minister of something in Poland, Warsaw. But the family was Polish and it was called Paderewski's and it was a rhythm section and the mother and the father, they did a show too and they sang and comedy and all that kind of stuff you know. And it was just trumpet and rhythm section. Well my brother had the gig first. And it was five nights a week — it was a nice supper club. And he had it first and then in Cleveland Gary Barone, I don't know if you know Gary Barone and the Barone brothers, Mike Barone and Gary Barone who is a trumpet player, and he is older, he is in between my brother's age and my age. And my brother left that gig and Gary did it. And then after Gary I got the gig. So I was sixteen and I'm playing. But what was great about it was we'd play all these tunes. I mean you name it, "Moon Over Miami," you know "Poor Butterfly," God I can go on and on and on. But I learned all these tunes. I knew a lot of them from playing Music Minus One which I did. I did that a lot and it was great. But I'm playing these tunes but when it would get to the bridge a lot of times I wouldn't remember the bridge. So I would play another bridge. Well Jan Paderewski, the piano player, it was his band.

written in and that's it. He could not improvise whatsoever. So it was just — so when I'd go into a bridge for another tune he was completely lost, he goes like what's he doing or what's going on. And then I'd come out of that eight into the last eight of the tune, into the melody of the song we were playing. You know I wasn't improvising I just played another bridge because I didn't know it at the time.

MR: You were doing Charles Ives.

CF: Yeah I was. But you know what? It was a great experience, it really was. To this day, sometimes but I mean when you think about it, now think about all these tunes, you could play so many bridges are so similar, it goes back to the, you know to the last eight of the tune so I mean, I mean, well you know exactly what I'm talking about.

MR: Did the rock & roll on AM radio enter this picture at all? Was that part of the repertoire?

CF: For me? My sister is a couple of years older than me so I'm the baby in the family. So when rock & roll came out in the '60's when it was happening, and she was driving and I wasn't driving yet, I was 14 but I mean she was 16. And we'd be driving in the car and she'd have AM radio on and playing all this rock & roll, and I hated it. Oh I hated it. I said, "Turn that off, turn that off, let's get the FM station so I can hear some jazz in Cleveland." And I just couldn't stand it. I really couldn't. The only group I really enjoyed listening to at all were the Beach Boys 'cause they had harmonies you know like 'cause I loved listening to like to well who's the group, the singing group I love so much — jazz, a wonderful jazz group.

MR: The Four Freshmen?

CF: Yeah the Four Freshmen, exactly. The Four Freshmen and that. So for AM records and for pop music the Beach Boys were the closest thing to that as far as 'cause they had voicings and it was real nice rather than just the rock & roll that was of the day. I did enjoy when Motown came out, this was later though. The Motown came out, and I did a lot of Motown and it was great you know. It was funky and it was loose, it was happy and precision didn't have to be — it wasn't part of the picture. You know precision — Buddy's band — you know he restricted, I mean he was very strict as far as precision but not to a degree of in other words if a clam, a little bubble I'd say, is beautiful you know. I mean a little signature. I do it, sometimes I do it purposely, a little [scats a note] you know a purposeful little thing I did. And then I may introduce that again later on I'll introduce it to show that it wasn't a mistake, that it was something that I actually chose to do. It's, you know it's — oh gosh, what can I say?

MR: Before I leave your childhood I just wondered what it was like to be making some money and going to high school or middle school, wherever you were. Did you stand out as a student like man, he's playing gigs?

CF: You know actually yes. That's true. When I was in middle school or junior high we called it then, junior high school. I was doing these, like I said I was doing these gigs and playing these and then making some money, not a lot of money but it was some cash you know. But I knew that I wanted to be a trumpet player already. I knew that because my brother was — jeez when I was 14 my brother was 22. He had already been on the road with the Ray McKinley band, the Glenn Miller band. He went out with Ralph Marterie's band before that. And I saw him, and then he buys a Triumph TR 3 and I'm thinking to myself jeez, brand new car and it's like a sports car, and I'm thinking well that's what I want to do. I was too young to look at anything else except having fun playing what I wanted to do music, and to be able to make money to live. And so I ended up just — I knew — do you remember in high school I don't know if you had to take an exam that said what you wanted to do in college. Well I remember, it was tenth grade. And I remember filling it out and just immediately, a musician. I knew exactly what I wanted to do. And everybody, all my friends, they were filling out this form, they had no idea what they wanted to do for a living. No idea. And I saw them after I went on the road — I was on the road for the summer of '65 with the Jimmy Dorsey band before I went to the Cleveland School of Music. And when I came back that first semester after I saw, I saw them. And every one of them had changed their major. Every single one of them changed. They had no idea what they wanted to do when they were in tenth grade in high school. Not one of them. I did. I knew 'cause I knew it when I was a kid that this was what I wanted to do. And what a beautiful life I've had you know, it's been absolutely fantastic.

MR: I was trying to come up with a description of that and it almost sounds like someone writes a book, "Chuck Makes Good," and it's all like fantastic.

CF: Yeah well, you said you read something like that?

MR: No I was thinking of almost like a childrens' book and an aspiration to be a musician and how these wonderful things kept happening to you but that you were ready.

CF: Well you know the training I had, like I said before, the training is very, very important. I mean you know Uan Rasey used to — okay let me give you this. I had a teacher by the name of Harry Herforth in Cleveland when I was in high school. Now before him the first teacher was a vaudeville trumpet player in Cleveland. And I did some — I even did a vaudeville gig. And it was one that was real vaudeville, it was down in Short Vincent in Cleveland and with an actual, you know, it was a burlesque show with the girls, all the girls and the tassels and the whole thing, and the pit band. And they were like oh, they had day gigs and at night they would play in the pit in this, for this vaudeville show. And I couldn't believe what I saw there. You know I mean you went into the basement and

watch the show and play to the show. And mainly added [sings] Ta-da you know when, 'cause they had great comedians too. There was one comedian, oh I can't think of his name at all but he was kind of a famous vaudeville comedian anyhow. And one of his — they did a line, a bit where he said to one of the girls he says, "What is your favorite song?" And she says, "The 'William Tell Overture.'" And I can't really tell this 'cause the kids'll see it but it was a rump-titty-rump-rump-rump. Right? Well you can imagine the girls you know. Okay. If you could see that.

MR: I don't know, I think you need to describe it a little bit more.

CF: But you don't mind? I mean if this goes on?

MR: No I don't mind.

CF: Oh okay. You can always edit it out. Okay so he says what's your favorite and she says The "William Tell Overture" and he said okay so there were seven girls. So he had one of the girls facing — her butt facing the audience you know, the audience I'm talking about just all men in there you know with hats in their laps. Then the other girls facing forward. I'm 16. Now another girl facing forward. And then another one facing with the butt facing us and then three girls in a row facing forward. So he goes, "Rump-titty-rump-titty-rump-rump-rump." And I mean, [sings] Ta-da! So now I'm 16 and these guys, I mean they're like sleeping pretty much in their chairs. There was a trombone player, a sax — yeah trombone, sax, and a drummer and a few things like that in the pit. And they would be sleeping until they'd hear the punch line, you know "Rump-titty-rump-titty-rump-rump-rump." Whap and, "Ta-da!" And so I mean and you couldn't get out of the pit so when they had to relieve themselves I mean my gosh I mean and I'm seeing this at 16 I'm like my goodness gracious, this is unbelievable. But it was when they had real, once again, this was real. It was not like a girlie bar you go to today or something with the dollar bills thrown at them I mean this was a real show. And it was wonderful. I mean I got to, I started so young and I'm now 76 and I'm going to be — I'm getting older, this year in December. Anyhow I'll be 77. But anyhow back then I caught the end of like the mutes and all the different plungers, we had a stand with, you'd have all the different mutes, you'd grab this one and if you didn't have enough time you'd put one in your lap you know and pick that up, put that in, throw that in and go [Ta-da-ta-da] Whap, whap, whap. In the hats you know. I learned all that. That's how I started with all of that. And then I went on the road, but that was the Jimmy Dorsey band and things like that. And big bands in Cleveland you would do 'cause you had — those were the charts. You had that — wah-wahs and you know just all different kinds of mutes and different sounds which was wonderful. You know, in the Jimmy Dorsey band there were a lot of Sy Oliver charts that were just wonderful, just wonderful. That was a great book, Jimmy's book. It really

was a wonderful book, more so — it swung a lot more than the Tommy Dorsey band, that book.

MR: Well you can't learn that, I don't think they teach that in jazz education now, maybe there's not a reason for it, but I'm envious that you had that experience and that down the road some of the things you did you say well this is easy compared to being in the pit.

CF: Oh absolutely. But once again I'm getting back to, it was fun you know, it was fun you know? Music should be fun. It should not be — well that's why I chose not to be a classical player. I didn't want to sit there and count a hundred bars and then come in. I wanted to play my horn. And that's why every night I'd go — every night on the road I'd go to a club and play, with different players. That's how I learned. That was the school — that was my college training, and learning how to play from different players all over the country. And all over the world for that matter. It was — that's the way I think it should be. Of course it's not, there's no opportunity for that anymore. You have college bands which are wonderful, you have North Texas, you've got — oh there's so many — Indiana, I'm sure your school is fantastic, Florida — there's a lot of places. I had a choice you know except our family was very poor and I got a full scholarship to the Cleveland Institute of Music. So, and I wanted to study with Bernard Adelstein. And Bernard was the class — he was the principal trumpet player with Cleveland. And I would do gigs with him in Cleveland, commercials, jingles, and I'd play first he'd play third. You know so we were good friends. So when I went on the road and I came out I had a full scholarship, he didn't know this and I came there to the school to study with him. And he said, "What are you doing here?" I said, "I'm here to study with you." He says, "No you're not, you go back on the road." Because he knew that's what I wanted to do. And it was very hard and I said, "No. I want to study with you. I want to learn from you what I can." And finally he gave in and said, "Okay but only if you come to my house and study with me at my house." Because he had all postgraduate students except me. I was the only one, an outsider. And these postgraduate students, I'd hear them play [scats] all over the place and I'm going oh my goodness, I can't do that you know. So he took me in, in his house, and I — it was great. Fantastic you know. So I learned from him and then he knew like I wanted to go back on the road and then I did, I went back on the road right away, with the Jimmy Dorsey band again, and then I got heard. I was in Cleveland playing in an R&B band and we opened for Woody Herman's band. And on Woody Herman's band was Bobby Shew. And that's when Bill Chase was playing. Bill was like the star of the Woody Herman band. But Shew was in the trumpet section. And I knew Bob, because he was on the road — I met Bobby when I was 12 or something like that. Because he was on the road with my brother on the Glenn Miller band. So I knew Bobby

wanted to see Bobby. And we were doing an R&B band, it was a wonderful R&B band and we were opening for him and we were rehearsing. And it was after they did their sound check and they took their break and we were rehearsing and he told Sal Nestico he says, "I want you to hear this kid." So they didn't leave, they went up and they sat all the way up in the very top of the venue to listen to me play. And Shew, Bobby and I, we're like brothers, real brothers. And next thing you know I get a call to fly to New York to audition for Buddy's band, because he was on Buddy's band after he left Woody. And I went in to audition. They must have auditioned a dozen trumpet players and Buddy was a stickler as far as like getting somebody to play. It was a split lead and jazz charts which it's hard to find somebody to play the split lead and jazz because that's what Shew and I did. We split that book right up down the middle you know. He'd play lead on one, I'd play jazz. I'd play lead on one and he'd play jazz. It was beautiful. And so I went in to audition in New York, Basin Street East. And I sat and I played and I thought I did a great job. But you know I was 18. So Buddy calls me into his dressing room to sit down in his dressing room. And he's there in a smoking jacket and he says to me, "Kid, you've got the gig." I said, "Oh fantastic, Buddy, man, wonderful." He said, "Except when you play your solos I want you to play like Sweets Edison." And I said, "Well I can't do that." I said, "If you want to get Sweets Edison then you call Sweets Edison." And then there was a pause and then he said, "Kid, you've got the gig." Because I stood up to him, I said I can't do that, you get him. So that was the old school. And the old school was give me a — I'll say it again — give me a prick that can play. There wasn't any nepotism like there is these days. These days it's just, you know I mean you'd be in a section where the guys didn't get along but they played great. That was what the deal was. And they always had great bands, great bands, you know it's very hard to find bands like that these days. Gordon Goodwin's band has a friendly band. They all get along great and there's no nepotism there, they're all great players. But I don't know how many bands are like that these days around the world. I'm sure there are, I just — but they're far and — you know there's no many of them I would say. I wish there were.

MR: That's a fascinating backstory to all that. I want to take you back to your busy studio life. I came across one of those on-line Chuck Findley discographies, you know, the never-ending scroll. And I started to count, literally, and I said this is not going to work. But what I did see is that in 1979, according to this list, you played on 26 LPs. Like that's more than two a month and everybody from Dolly Parton to Tom Scott. So I don't have a question, it's simply an observation. But I wonder if you can describe, let's jump ten years later, 1989, a day in the life of Chuck Findley when you were on the Tonight Show band, what was a typical weekday like for you?

CF: Well that was wonderful actually. Well it was not really nice, I mean John Audino had passed away and I was in Germany. I was doing a little tour with Peter Herbolzheimer in Germany. And I was considering actually moving there because our son was young and I wanted him to get the culture and learn other languages other than just English. I wanted him to learn German and go to schools there. They know three or four languages everybody over there. They speak and you feel like a fool when I went over there the first time just speaking English and you know, learning a few words here and there. But we don't get that training here you know. Then once again if I went to Oregon there would be another language, or if I went to Nevada it would be a different language. So Europe is different in that aspect. But in '89 John Audino passed away and I was in Germany and I was in Hamburg. And actually Doc Severinsen called my wife to tell her first and to find out where I was and she said that I was in Hamburg, Germany. And he told her about Johnny passing, and that he would love me to do the gig. And Johnny and I were so close and just wonderful, what a marvelous man and player he was. And in that trumpet section was Conte Candoli and Snooky and Johnny and Maury Harris. Well Johnny had passed. So Doc and I go way back to 1965 when I first met Doc. But that was another story, I could tell you that real quick if you want.

MR: Sure.

CF: I was on the Jimmy Dorsey band and we were on Long Island playing at a country club. And I was doing some Carmine Caruso exercises warming up before the gig. We had quite a few hours, maybe two or three hours before the gig started at this golf course/country club. So I went up and I'm doing some exercises, and I went up to a high F. And out of the woods a trumpet answers me with a high F. Now I'm 17 and the guys in the band are like ribbing me about oh boy Chuck, they're a dime a dozen here in New York in the Big Apple. So then I went up to a high F sharp. Out of the woods comes a high F sharp. I'm like Jesus, now they're getting even more on me. I go up to high G. A high G comes out. An A flat, A flat comes out. A double A, a double A comes out. Now they're really, really ribbing me you know. And I'm thinking to myself okay enough of this nonsense, so I went up and played a double D and I held it really good, nice and strong. Dead silence out of the woods. Dead silence. And then all of a sudden you hear [scats rapidly] and I said that's Doc, that's got to be Doc, it has to be Doc Severinsen, not some young kid that you're talking about in New York. So I go to the woods, and I think this other trumpet player Gene Benson went with me. And we go through the woods and that was when Doc was rehearsing his little band. So we had over an hour or so, more than that, before the gig started. So I'm sitting there with Doc and he asked me how I did that. And I told him of Carmine Caruso, I studied with Carmine, and everybody was. He

are. Okay. So anyhow I showed him the exercises, the six notes, the harmonic series, and then the seconds, to build up you strong, that's the muscle building exercise. And I showed that to him and I gave him that lesson in the woods. And that was, I was 17 and he was 37. He's 20 years older than me. So then I'm on Buddy's band — that was the first meeting. Then I'm on Buddy's band in '66 and I joined the band, and the Tonight Show was traveling different places. We were in Chicago and the Tonight Show was there in Chicago and Johnny and Doc, and Doc did come to the gig. Because Johnny loved Buddy. He played drums and he just loved Buddy, just loved him. So they're sitting there and once again I meet Doc and Doc's there and I'm playing with Shew and we're just roaring up there with Buddy's band. He loved it. And then of course here in L.A. I'd run into him every now and then, and then Hamburg — getting back to where I started when I got called to do the gig. So what happened is that my wife called all the other guys in the band to come to my room so it wouldn't be a shock and I'd have my friends with me. So we went down to the bar. I was wondering why they all came to my room. It was after the gig and it's a normal time to go schloffing, you know, go to sleep you know. So we go down to the bar and order cognac and we're drinking cognac down there. And I go up to my room and Seely calls me and tells me that Johnny had passed away and that Doc wanted me to take Johnny's place. So then Doc called me the next day and the rest is history, and that's when I was on the band. Now that was a wonderful gig because there was no contract with NBC. The contracts ended when the Tonight Show moved out to L.A. In New York they were signed, you had contracts with NBC or you know they were like lifetime contracts. And that ended. And Snooky had to stay actually for a year and so did Tommy Newsom I think, a couple of guys had to stay before they moved to L.A. to finish out their contract for their buy-out. So they stayed for a year. And that's when Jimmy Zito was on the band and they had, I don't know who took — well they had enough trumpet players anyhow with Johnny before Snooky moved out. And then when Johnny passed Snooky was there. There was no contracts anymore with NBC or MGM or Paramount, none of them. They were all individual — you just went in and worked for the company, right? Well the gig was great because if I wanted to do records I could do records, I could send a sub to the Tonight Show. So I wasn't being stifled as far as my doing records because I was so busy doing records. But I always made it a point to be there because I loved it so much. So I'd do the Tonight Show, but that didn't start 'til 1:00, 2:00 in the afternoon. So I could do a morning record date. I could work at Paramount, I mean Universal, I could work Paramount, I could do a record date and then I'd do the afternoon date with the Tonight Show and then all night I'd record and I'd work 'til two in the morning or something like that.

CF: Well that's another thing, from two 'til well probably four in the morning 'til eight, three in the morning 'til eight. I'd get four, five hours sleep. You know? And then go to work. But you know when you're that busy doing things all the time, I was so used to it. It was no big deal. I was having so much fun you know what can I say?

MR: Let me ask you if you became a popular call to come in and solo as well as the section work, did you find that after you did it a lot that you might try to alter your style a bit depending on the artist or the producer?

CF: Oh yeah. You have to make them happy.

MR: How did you learn — you just learned from experience that Quincy Jones would like this kind of thing and Barbra Streisand would like something different?

CF: Of course. That's from, once again, playing all different styles and listening, you have to listen. You listen to records, listen to the radio, you've got to listen to what's going on. And I listened to Sweets, like I said, you know, somebody would say well I want you to play like Sweets, I want you to play like Miles. I had it in my head. It was in there. All the motors were in there that had all that information in the computer you know? It was all in here. And I just had to pull it out and say okay, I know that, I know how to do that and I'll do my best job sounding like him but it's going to be me, my soul and my being like Sweets or like Conte Candoli or Snooky or Maynard whenever they had me do the Maynard or whatever I had to do I did it. But I had the knowledge from listening. And you just — once again, that's being a soloist, you know, being like — you know if they wanted a Dixieland solo I'd play a Dixieland solo. Mariachi vibrato is different than Italian vibrato. They're different. So if they wanted the mariachi vibrato you'd use the mariachi vibrato. If they wanted Italian vibrato, you used an Italian vibrato. They're all different. But that you can only learn by listening. And you have to listen. And I was fortunate enough to be able to sit next and listen to them live. You can't get that kind of schooling. That schooling is — you know what you're doing is wonderful 'cause you can play — at least these students can listen and get something out of it. You know like I told you before, Bobby Hackett was first. And if they haven't listening to Bobby Hackett, they need to listen to Bobby Hackett. Bix Beiderbecke. Listen to Bix Beiderbecke. Listen to Charlie Shavers. You know? Listen to these people and listen to Pops. You know with Sweets we were doing the "Hollywood Palace" with Louie Bellson's band, and Louie was married to — oh my goodness — you know she was Pearly Mae was

MR: Pearl Bailey.

CF: Yeah. Pearly Mae. She was fantastic. And she had a show at the Hollywood Palace and the band was Louie's big band and I was in it and Sweets was in it and Conte Candoli and John Audino was the trumpet section. And Pops is on the show one day. Actually it

very well. And he came over and was with us all day. And I got to hang out with Pops, with Satchmo, with Louis Armstrong all day. And it was two days I got to hang with him. And one of the — I mean that kind of experience and that was so beautiful just to listen to him talk and to talk to him, and him and Sweets, the two of them going back and forth telling stories about this and about that. And you know so just me being around all these people I got to meet all the legends and all my idols. All my idols I got to meet them all. And it was that kind of an experience that you don't really get these days. I mean those people are all gone anyhow. So the only way you can listen to them is listen to records. Listen to everything they play.

MR: Isn't it amazing that those gentlemen, especially the black musicians who went through so much trial over the years, still had that life force that you — as you describe like sitting next to them for a couple of hours, like you just feel better afterwards.

CF: Oh jeez, it's heaven. It's heavenly I mean it really was. Wow. I mean I never thought that would happen. And then Miles Davis, another one. I saw him in New York. You know we didn't get to hang, it was a different situation. That was when I did the album "Dingo" with Miles. Do you know that album? And the story, and he was in the movie you know. And when I did that I had to be some — when you mentioned I had to be somebody you know, Lalo Schifrin — I mean Michel Legrand it was, and I go into the studio to do this and it's an Australian production. And if you know the movie, I won't get into it but in the movie he's in Australia, but there's a kid in the movie that wants to be a trumpet player and heard Miles play at the airport and wanted to be — and Miles says to him, "Well, you know kid, whenever — if you ever come to New York you can come and sit in with me. So anyhow I was that kid in the movie, the trumpet player. So Michel Legrand says to me, "Chuck come in here, I want you to hear — you have to be this person. So I want you to listen to this." So he's playing me this cassette tape of all these different sounds in Australia. Well I'm a golfer and I had been to Australia a few times and I was out playing golf before this all happened you know, a few years before. And I heard all these birds and all these different sounds in Australia that you don't hear on this continent. And so I had an idea what this kid heard. So that was in my head and I knew that, so I had to be a jazz player but somebody from the Outback that in his head had all these different sounds. So I used, I did a thing where I would open up the spit valve on the tuning slide. And you'd go [scats] with that, 'cause there's no center. So you can swim all over the place with that. I kind of put that in there, other different things that I put in as this kid. And I'm on every other track on that album with Miles. But unfortunately Miles was sick, that was when Miles was really getting sick, right before he passed. And he didn't come in for those sessions. He came in by himself so I didn't really

him in New York, going back to New York and the Village, and once again it was a very brief meeting. I sat down next to him in a bar, or he came in, I was at the bar. We were in back with the orchestra with Jack Elliott and Allyn Ferguson. And we did it live at Studio 8H in New York. So we got there and got to the Village when we flew in and everything was closing. But we went into this one place, we went into the Brecker Brothers' club and that was closed. They were all closed already. But this one club in the Village who wanted to have a taste myself and Vince DeRosa on French horn and a few other players. And I'm sitting there, and I was the only one sitting at the bar. I ordered a cognac I think. And next thing I know, next to me is Miles sitting there. And now the interesting thing is I knew that Miles was doing a new album because a dear friend of mine by the name of Doc Lawless, who was also Buddy Rich's road manager when I was on the band, is the uncle of Hines, Hines & Dad. So he was telling me, he said, "Chuck," he was my limo driver actually, he drove me there. He had a limo pick us up in New York. So he says to me, he says, "You know, Chuck," he says, "I'm driving Miles around, he's doing a new album." And I said, "Really, how wonderful." Now Miles is sitting next to me and I said, "Miles, my name is Chuck Findley" and I said, "by the way, I love your new album." And he says, "How could you? It's not out yet." And I was talking about the prior album that he had just released you know. And that was the end of that, he got up and went downstairs to the bathroom and I never saw him again. So anyhow, just meetings like that you know. That's what he does.

MR: I have to tell you that you know you made me think, I'll tell our viewers that we had a 2:00 my time appointment for the Zoom and you dinged me at ten of. And I got this flash of Joe Wilder. You know Joe?

CF: I didn't know Joe.

MR: Well he just said this thing, he was so meticulous and such a pro and he talked about how it's better to be an hour early than a minute late and the whole thing. And anyway that was just an aside. But thanks for the memory, 'cause I got to know Joe pretty well. I had something I wanted to share with you. I've been fortunate to have sessions with a lot of your colleagues. And we were talking, I had a question for one of them who in your phrase will remain anonymous. But I asked him if the L.A. scene, after you've done it for a bunch of years ever got tedious or a chore. And he said, "This isn't playing. It's craft. L.A. is an incredible place for craft. You really learn to play your instrument well and in tune, to show up on time, the disciplines of the craft are there but your soul, your spirit you know, is not usually nurtured.

CF: Well you know I don't know if I agree with that. It is a craft, that it is absolutely. But it's how you take it I think, and how you approach that. You know I've come in from one

down and do it and do my job. I think maybe that's what this person was explaining was doing your job. Yeah you have to do your job and you have to be prepared for it. But you never know what you're going to get. So being versatile is the answer to that. You have to be versatile. Like I mentioned earlier about Italian vibrato and mariachi vibrato. A Dixieland solo. Bebop, hard bop solo. They're all different. But you have to be able to do all that because you never know what you're going to get. But like I said earlier as well is that you know there are players that play notes. That's — okay that's what you do you know. And you could be a good section player there. But being a nice person as well in the section, they're the ones that really need to be nice to be able to be in that section. They could play the part, fine, but I mean there are many, many people that could do that. But as an artist, as a soloist, that's another thing altogether.

MR: I'm going to share another thing from — here's what Tom Scott had to say about that question. And he said that he did some sessions with a producer that did The Partridge Family and David Cassidy records. And he said, "The horn section at that time was me, Chuck Findley, Ollie Mitchell, Slyde Hyde and Lou McCurry. So even if the tune was kind of dumb or mundane it didn't matter. We were there to play the best damn horn section you've ever heard in your life. We took our part very seriously. We didn't know how far in the mix it was going to be or whether it was going to be there at all. Our job was to go in there and play with one another which we took great joy in doing. Whatever the music is, man, we'll nail it. So that was soul gratifying just to do that, regardless of the artist."

CF: We did that all the time. And actually Mike Melvoin wrote all those charts for that particular album. But we always, one thing I always did, always did after a session, whether it was good or bad I mean the track. I'm not talking about what we did but I'm just, like Tom said, we would make the record. We were like the icing on the cake you know. You know you build a house but you need to decorate it. We decorated it. We decorated all kinds of things you know and make it sellable, this house. You know? Because it didn't look very good without any decoration, without it being painted or furnished or, you know, everything else that makes a house beautiful. Same thing with like a cake and you put the icing on it. And that's what we did. And but I would always say thank you and good luck with your project. Always. Because I want to thank them for the gig and I also wanted to thank them and hope that they did well on their project because there were many, many records that were not really necessarily a great song or anything but we made magic on those songs. And they did make money off it. And they did have a hit. If you heard the basic tracks without the horns, without us on it, then huh, what can I say? I mean you could listen to them and a lot of them are great, a lot of them

MR: What kind of thing, this could be a pro or a con, but would you go home and bother to bring up what your day was like? What kind of sessions?

CF: Occasionally. You know I actually, if I did I told my wife and she is my dictionary and my encyclopedia. She tells me what I did and what I didn't do 'cause I did so many things, you know, I mean the ones that really stuck out of course, like doing the "Dingo" album with Michel Legrand or Al Jarreau things I did, or there was so many things. Bangledesh you know with George Harrison, my goodness you know, how fantastic that was, and the tour we did. Peter Herbolzheimer in Germany, you know things I did there. Many, many things. The album I did with Bobby Shew, "Trumpets No End" what a fantastic album and to this day one of my all-time favorites you know. It's a beautiful. And Shew and I, like I mentioned, are like real brothers. You know my mom said one time when she saw the album cover, she said, she said, "Jeez I didn't know I had another son" my mom said when she looked at it, you know? And also knowing how close Bobby and I are.

MR: Yeah. Bobby said that my wife could tell by the look on my face how my day went in the studios when I got home.

CF: Oh yeah, of course Lisa could. You know Bobby decided after — you know he could have done what I did in the studios, but he decided to teach and go out and play jazz, he wanted to do that. He didn't want to be in the studios like I did. I mean he would have enjoyed it and loved a lot of the stuff but he really wanted to be freer than that. He wanted to be a bird, a flying bird playing jazz you know. I didn't have the hours that he had to do it because I was in the studio. And I'd have to go out on weekends and do like concerts and things like that. I did play in clubs, I did a lot of club playing with Don Menza and the sextet, but that was wonderful — we played and we did all kinds of stuff, so I was always playing in clubs at night. So that's on top of all the other things, so talking about sleep, that took up some of my sleep too. But I'm still here, Monk.

MR: If you had an offer to do like a three week tour with some fantastic band that was put together to do a tour of the country, would that have been hard for you, like you're taking yourself out of the scene and you're not making the dates people want?

CF: Are you talking about back in the day or now?

MR: Yeah back in the day.

CF: Yeah I really didn't do much of that. I would just record for them and then they would get bands and musicians to take on the road. You know I just did the records. I really didn't, I was so busy I was enjoying going home for lunch, you know I lived in Studio City and I'd be at Universal and I'd come home for lunch and Seely would have lunch with me. Or dinner. I lived close. I always wanted to be close. And I would tell musicians

you get a last minute call, somebody can't make it or their car broke down or they got — whatever, something happened, and we need somebody right away, you get a phone call and we need you right away you know. Can you get there in like 20 minutes or something like that. And so back in those days you could. If you lived in North Hollywood, Studio City, anywhere like that, everything was in Hollywood pretty much or Burbank. Pretty much Hollywood, the studios are in Hollywood. And they could be there in 15 minutes, 20 minutes.

MR: Well pre-cell phone, did you have beepers or something?

CF: No. We didn't have anything. This was before pagers or any of that. It was just go to the pay phone or use the studio phone and call them and say can you get here right away. And they'd come as fast as they could. Oh no, those are times when we were concerned — when somebody was late we were concerned about the fact that maybe they were in an accident or they got sick. That was our concern. It wasn't — it had nothing to do with the business like somebody running over on a session. You know that happened all the time. Say somebody's ten minutes late, okay we'll start with the ten. Because they're in traffic. And there was no panic, everything was fine, you know it was relaxed. And we would always get it done and with smiles on their faces and our faces too. As we'd leave and go do another session. So it was all good, Monk.

MR: Yeah. This has just been a fantastic conversation. I'll just wrap up with maybe two things. I understand that you did some jamming with Pilar Arcos?

CF: With who?

MR: Pilar Arcos.

CF: Oh Arcos. That's my wife's grandmother.

MR: Oh yeah.

CF: She was a famous Latin, from Spain, opera singer pretty much. I mean she did — back in the early '20's I guess it was, she did, she was with RCA Victor and what other — my wife — what other label, honey? Oh Brunswick as well. But that was when they did titles you know, one title. And she would go in to the studios and do these different titles. And she recorded, jeez, thousands of titles you know back in the day. And she would travel and she was very big in South America and traveled all over. She was born in Cuba and from a circus family you know. So I married into a family of circus people, entertainers you know.

MR: Well you came out of a family of musicians too so you've got it surrounded.

CF: I am definitely surrounded by all music and art. And like I said before, I thought everybody's house had music and live music in it all the time you know. And that would be wonderful, that would be great for kids. You know when I was growing up I would

three of us were real close. And we'd go to Ernie's house in his basement and we would play out of the Real Book, and we would play tunes just me and Ernie, no bass just drums and tenor and trumpet. And we'd play tune after tune after tune and we'd just, that's how we learned to play there you know, in the basement, learning tunes and stuff. And I think that's very, very important, outside of school for these students to get together, form a band, play tunes. You know you don't need a — it's really good with just a trumpet and tenor and drums.

MR: Yeah you've got to make your own harmony and etcetera.

CF: Absolutely. Just playing. I played a bass line, I walked a bass line when the tenor would play the solo and then he would walk a bass line when I'd solo. Very, very good, it's a great experience and I think they'd learn a lot from that. That's things that they can do that they can't get in school.

MR: Well the business has changed a lot so just to wrap up, do you have any advice for the young trumpet player out there who wants to do what you did?

CF: Yes I do actually. If you want to have something you can have it. So if you want to be a trumpet player for a living you can do that. There's room for great players and there always will be. So a student trumpet player that wants to become a studio musician or play jazz and make records and things like that they can do that. It's up to them, entirely up to them. But there's always room, there's always going to be jazz around, there's always going to be records being done, there's always going to be music period. But they need to learn to be a versatile player. You can't just do one style you know. You should be able to play a classical piece you know, not necessarily a principal trumpet player in an orchestra, but be able to approach it properly. And a lot of that is mental and knowing how to attack the notes and where to breathe properly. That's what has to do with classical music, there's a politic. There's a lot of things that you need to do. Now that is necessary. That's the basis. Now you've learned how to walk. Now you need to learn how to jog and then you learn other stuff. And then listening to records and listening to everybody playing. Pick-up, pick their brains by records. Because you're not going to be able to do it live, like I had the opportunity to do. Let them listen and pick the brains on records of everybody's playing. Learn that. Play along with it. Learn it. Transcribe it, it's wonderful. Transcribe the solo. When you transcribe it then you really know it and then you can look at it and study it and say oh okay, and look at the chord changes and see what you did to the chord change, you know? And once again all styles, Dixieland, like I said you know bebop, mainstream, you name it. It all needs to be done but you have to be versatile. And also these days you need to know how to use Pro Tools and all that kind of stuff because they're going to be asked to do that 'cause that's the way it is and it's not

have that in their file that they can do that. Because they'll be called to do a solo and you'll do it at home in your room and you put the solo and you fly it to them and they've got your solo. I do that.

MR: Yeah.

CF: If they ask for a solo I just do a solo and send it to them you know because it's easier than traveling these days and it's a lot cheaper for them not to fly me somewhere.

MR: Yeah, fantastic. Thank you so much, you've been very generous with your time and I'll pause our recording here and say our good-byes. Thanks a lot, Chuck.

CF: Thank you, Monk.